Passing the Flame

Othello, or the trap of theatrical illusion. Ten lessons, the spirale de Gorse, a midpoint commentary and a summative assessment.

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Specialism LLCER English · Terminale of the lycée général et technologique

Programme of BO spécial n° 8 of 25 July 2019: thematic areas « Arts et débats d'idées » and « Expression et construction de soi » (axis « Mise en scène de soi »). Level C1.



Théodore Chassériau, Othello et Desdémone à Venise, 1849-1850, oil on wood, Musée du Louvre, Paris, RF 3897, public domain.

Guiding question

How does Shakespeare turn theatre itself into a trap of perception in Othello, and what does that trap still teach us about language, jealousy and the courage to read between the lines?

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Othello, or the trap of theatrical illusion

A C1 sequence in English for the spécialité LLCER anglais, Terminale of the lycée général et technologique, and for students heading to hypokhâgne or the first year of a Licence LLCER.

Guiding question. How does Shakespeare turn theatre itself into a trap of perception in *Othello*, and what does that trap still teach us about language, jealousy and the courage to read between the lines?

Programme. This sequence is anchored in the programme of the spécialité Langues, littératures et cultures étrangères et régionales, anglais, Terminale (Bulletin officiel spécial n° 8 of 25 July 2019), in particular the axes « Arts et débats d'idées » and « Expression et construction de soi » (and its related emphasis on the mise en scène

de soi). *Othello* is offered here as a demanding literary and dramaturgical object, not as a text invented for a programme limitatif.

Level. The work is pitched at C1 throughout: close reading of verse, control of critical vocabulary, comparison of public-domain criticism, and a first approach to the commentary practised in classe préparatoire. The sequence assumes a strong Terminale class; it does not divide the demand into a lower tier and a later C1 extension.

Shakespeare's text. All quotations follow a public-domain English text (Project Gutenberg ebook 1531, based on a nineteenth-century edition of the play). Act, scene and a short cue are given each time. In class, students may align line numbers with the Folger Shakespeare Library Digital Text, which remains an excellent working edition. Translation work, when it appears, uses only the public-domain French of François-Victor Hugo. Yves Bonnefoy and Jean-Michel Déprats are not used.

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Dédicace

« À la mémoire du Professeur Pierre Spriet,

et à tous mes maîtres des classes préparatoires et de l'Université Bordeaux III,

qui m'ont appris à lire le monde entre les lignes.

Aux artistes de la Royal Shakespeare Company (Stratford-upon-Avon, 1984-85),

qui m'ont montré que l'amour du texte rend les êtres meilleurs.

Aux élèves de Terminale qui s'apprêtent à entrer en Hypokhâgne ou en Licence d'Anglais :

puisse cette flamme devenir la vôtre. »

Note d'intention

Ce dossier est né d'un élan de gratitude. Il ne prétend à aucun titre académique : il est le témoignage d'une amoureuse des mots, de la langue anglaise et de la langue française, dont toute la vie intérieure a été éclairée par des passeurs généreux. À travers une étude approfondie du piège théâtral dans Othello et quatre explications de texte modèles (dont la scène d'espionnage de l'Acte IV, scène 1), il invite les futurs étudiants à découvrir que la littérature n'est jamais un savoir mort, mais une école de lucidité et d'humanité.

How this sequence is organised

The sequence comprises **ten lessons** of 55 minutes, timed on 52. In every lesson a **stopping point** (checkpoint) falls at about minute 44, so that the last eight minutes can either complete the main task or open an **emergency exit**: a shorter, still demanding close that leaves no student without a finished thought. The phrase « spirale de Gorse » is kept in French, as the name of the method. Credit: Méthode de la spirale de Gorse conçue par Madame Carole Paoli Pompougnac.

Each lesson includes a spoken turn, a written record, a vocabulary rubric titled **Expanding your vocabulary** or **Building your vocabulary**, a short grammar focus, and homework. British English is used throughout, including in the teacher's notes.

The midpoint assessment sits after Lesson 5. Lesson 10 is the summative hour.

A five-minute video essay by Madame Carole Paoli Pompougnac opens the work (homage to Professor Pierre Spriet, Bordeaux III, and the RSC at Stratford, 1984-85). Four model close readings accompany Lessons 2, 3, 5, 6 and 8.

The ten turns of the spiral

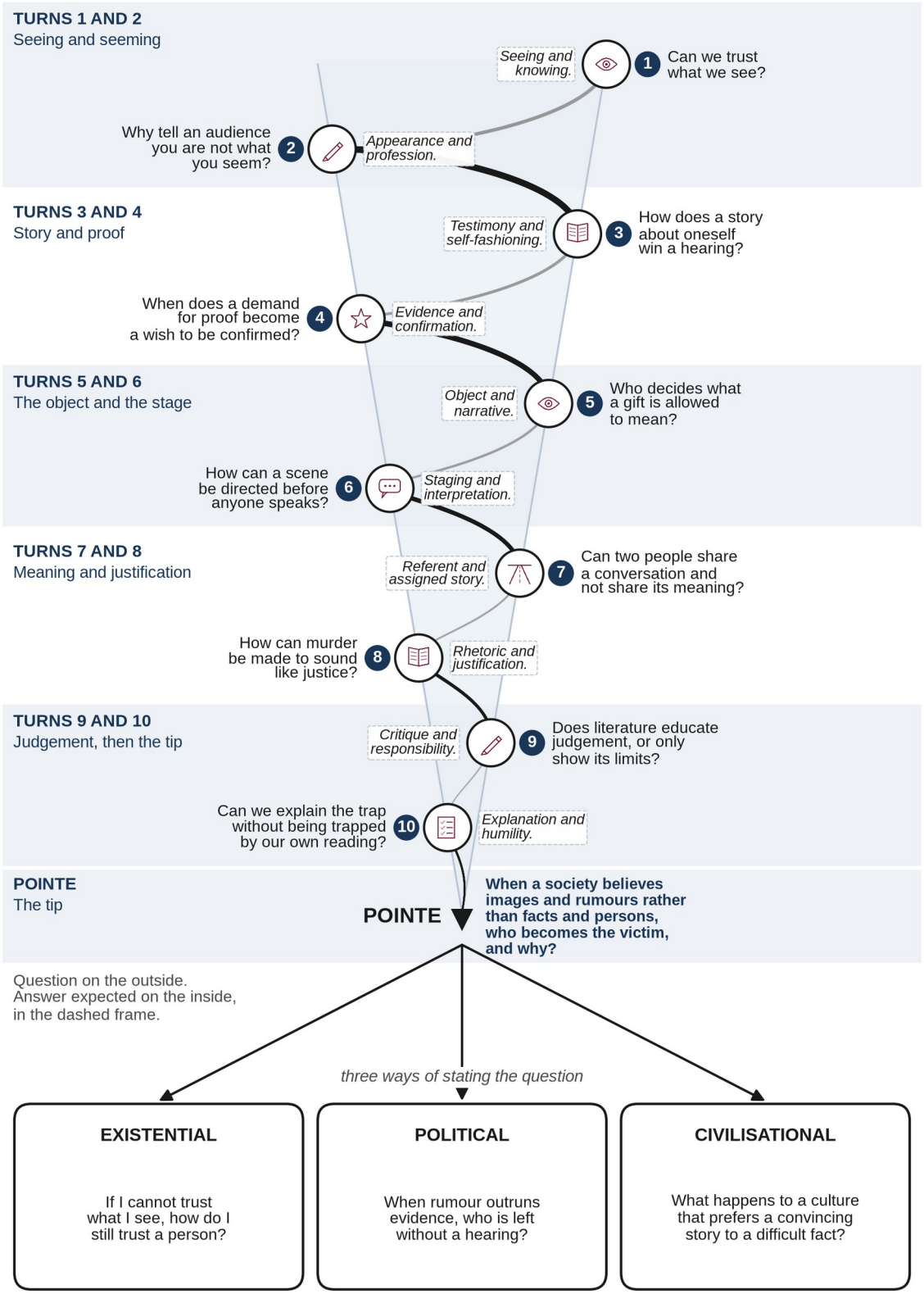


Diagram of the spirale de Gorse: ten turns tighten towards a tip, which opens into three paths, existential, political and civilisational.
Méthode de la spirale de Gorse conçue par Madame Carole Paoli Pompougnac.

The method is the spirale de Gorse. Ten turns tighten towards a tip. The tip then opens into three paths: existential, political and civilisational.

Turn 1. Can we trust what we see? Seeing and knowing.

Turn 2. Why tell an audience you are not what you seem? Appearance and profession.

Turn 3. How does a story about oneself win a hearing? Testimony and self-fashioning.

Turn 4. When does a demand for proof become a wish to be confirmed? Evidence and confirmation.

Turn 5. Who decides what a gift is allowed to mean? Object and narrative.

Turn 6. How can a scene be directed before anyone speaks? Staging and interpretation.

Turn 7. Can two people share a conversation and not share its meaning? Referent and assigned story.

Turn 8. How can murder be made to sound like justice? Rhetoric and justification.

Turn 9. Does literature educate judgement, or only show its limits? Critique and responsibility.

Turn 10. Can we explain the trap without being trapped by our own reading? Explanation and humility.

The tip. When a society believes images and rumours rather than facts and persons, who becomes the victim, and why?

From that tip, three paths:

- **Existential.** If I cannot trust what I see, how do I still trust a person?
- **Political.** When rumour outruns evidence, who is left without a hearing?
- **Civilisational.** What happens to a culture that prefers a convincing story to a difficult fact?

Méthode de la spirale de Gorse conçue par Madame Carole Paoli Pompougnac.

A first table of figures and dramatic devices

Students are expected to name the device, locate it, and say what it *does* in the trap of perception. The table is a working instrument, not a list to be learnt by heart without examples.

Device	A first bearing in *Othello*	What to listen for
Antithesis and paradox	« I am not what I am » (I.1)	A profession of identity that cancels itself; the spectator is invited into a pact of knowing.
Dramatic irony	Emilia's « I know not, madam » (III.4); the handkerchief already stolen	The audience holds a fact the stage victim does not hold.
Aside	Othello, « O, hardness to dissemble! » (III.4)	A private truth spoken beside the public word; theatre showing its own double speech.
Metaphor	« the green-ey'd monster » (III.3)	Jealousy given a body that feeds on what it looks at.
Sententia	« our new heraldry is hands, not hearts » (III.4)	A compact moral proverb that may be wiser than the speaker's use of it.
Ekphrasis (of an object)	The Egyptian handkerchief, the sibyl, the mummy (III.4)	Description that *installs* a meaning rather than reports one.
Aposiopesis	Broken lines, « The handkerchief! » repeated (III.4)	Speech that fails, and in failing becomes a command.
Prolepsis	Brabantio, « She has deceiv'd her father, and may thee » (I.3)	A future planted as a warning, later harvested as « proof ».
Anadiplosis and repetition	« Put out the light, and then put out the light » (V.2)	A word turned, in the turning, from lamp to life.
Hypotyposis	Othello's travel tale (I.3): antres, deserts, Anthropophagi	A vivid scene made present in words, used to win a hearing.

Device	A first bearing in *Othello*	What to listen for
Chiasmus	« She lov'd me for the dangers I had pass'd, / And I lov'd her that she did pity them » (I.3)	Two loves balanced, and made to look like one cause.
Soliloquy	Iago's self-explanations (I.1, I.3, II.3)	A character who seems to take the audience into his confidence.

Public-domain critics at a glance

Longer extracts and a translation exercise appear in Lesson 9. Modern critics (T. S. Eliot, F. R. Leavis, Northrop Frye, René Girard, Stephen Greenblatt) may be named as invitations to further reading; they are not quoted at length here, because their work is not in the public domain.

Critic	Work (public domain)	A bearing to take into class
Thomas Rymer	*A Short View of Tragedy* (1693)	A hostile, useful attack: he mocks the handkerchief and calls the tragedy a « Bloody Farce ». Students must answer him, not dismiss him.
Samuel Johnson	Notes on *Othello*, in *The Plays of William Shakespeare* (1765)	The « fiery openness of Othello, magnanimous, artless, and credulous » set against « the cool malignity of Iago ».
S. T. Coleridge	Lectures and notes on Shakespeare (early nineteenth century, later printed)	Iago and « the motive-hunting of a motiveless malignity ».
William Hazlitt	*Characters of Shakespear's Plays* (1817)	Character as moral and theatrical energy; Iago's intellect in the service of harm.
A. C. Bradley	*Shakespearean Tragedy* (1904)	Othello as « the most romantic figure among Shakespeare's heroes »; a study of noble nature wrought upon.

François-Victor Hugo, *Othello ou le More de Venise*, in his public-domain translation of Shakespeare, is the only French version used for comparative work.

Map of the ten lessons

1. Inheriting a way of reading. The video essay, the dedication, Chassériau, the spiral, a diagnostic.
2. Iago's invitation: « I am not what I am » (I.1).
3. The Senate: a story that wins a hearing (I.3). « Her father lov'd me »; « Look to her, Moor »; « My life upon her faith. »
4. The desire for proof (III.3). The green-eyed monster; « Haply, for I am black »; ocular proof.
5. The handkerchief and the test of trust (III.4). Mandatory close reading. Midpoint assessment follows this lesson.
6. Directing the spectator (IV.1). Othello made to watch a scene whose meaning has been prepared for him.
7. One conversation, two meanings. Bianca, the handkerchief, and the assignment of a story.
8. The language of justification (V.2). « Put out the light »; « Speak of me as I am. »
9. What can literature teach? Public-domain critics, Hugo, a debate on judgement.
10. Explaining the trap. Summative commentary and a short director's commentary.

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Lesson 1. Inheriting a way of reading

Turn of the spiral. Can we trust what we see? Seeing and knowing.

Aims. To receive the sequence as a homage and as a method; to watch the video essay with a listener's attention; to look at Chassériau's *Othello et Desdémone à Venise* without treating the painting as a mere illustration; to enter the spirale de Gorse; to write a short diagnostic that already practices C1 precision.

Corpus. The five-minute video essay by Madame Carole Paoli Pompougnac; the French dédicace and note d'intention (read as a gift of tone, not as a text to be translated in class); Théodore Chassériau, *Othello et Desdémone à Venise*, 1849-1850, Louvre RF 3897; the guiding question.

Timing (55 minutes, timed on 52)

Minutes	Work
0-8	First viewing of the video essay, without notes. One sentence, spoken, on what the voice is doing: remembering, teaching, or both.
8-18	Second viewing, with a listening grid: who is named, what gesture is remembered (the opening of a bilingual edition), what is meant by an « educated imagination ».
18-30	The painting. Three observations only, each tied to a pictorial fact (gesture, gaze, light, interval between the two figures). No plot summary.
30-44	The spirale de Gorse: the idea of a tightening, the ten turns, the tip. Students propose a first answer to turn 1, in two carefully built sentences.
44	Stopping point. Whatever is unfinished is gathered in one claim.
44-52	Diagnostic (or emergency exit: three sentences on what « reading between the lines » asks of a spectator of theatre).

Speaking turn. In no more than one minute, name a person who taught you to read carefully (a teacher, a parent, a friend, a librarian) and describe one precise gesture, not a general tribute.

Written record. A diagnostic of 180 to 220 words: « What does it mean, in the theatre, to read between the lines, and why might that courage also be dangerous? » The best answers will already distinguish seeing, interpreting, and knowing.

Emergency exit (8 minutes). Three sentences only. Sentence 1: one fact from the video or the painting. Sentence 2: one inference. Sentence 3: one question you are willing to keep open.

Expanding your vocabulary

homage; transmission; subtext; perception; theatrical illusion; reverence; torchbearer; to inherit a method; to read between the lines; educated imagination; mise en scène; spectator; to pass on (a flame, a way of reading).

Practise each word in a sentence that could stand in a commentary, not in a tautology. Example: « The spectator inherits a privileged knowledge that the character on stage does not share: that privilege is already a moral test. »

Grammar for commentary

Relative clauses that carry a judgement, not only a description: « Chassériau, whose Venetian interior holds closeness and unease in the same frame, invites a reading that refuses mere illustration. » Aim for at least one such sentence in the diagnostic.

Homework

1. Read I.1, from Roderigo's opening to Iago's « I am not what I am ». Mark every word that concerns seeming, service, or the heart.
2. Learn Iago's closing movement by heart, from « For when my outward action » to « I am not what I am ».
3. In your journal (120 words, C1): why might a villain wish to make the audience his accomplice?

Towards a first model (short)

A useful diagnostic does not retell the video. It takes one remembered gesture (a bilingual edition opened with care) and one pictorial fact (an interval of space, a direction of gaze), and asks how both train the same attention: the attention that will be required when Iago, in the next lesson, tells us he is not what he is. Transmission, here, is not a soft theme. It is a discipline of looking.

Lesson 2. Iago's invitation: « I am not what I am »

Turn of the spiral. Why tell an audience you are not what you seem? Appearance and profession.

Aims. To close-read Iago's self-description in I.1 as a theatrical contract with the spectator; to distinguish motive, pretext, and performance; to hear the biblical echo without reducing the line to a footnote; to write a first formal paragraph in a prépa spirit.

Corpus. *Othello*, I.1, Iago's speech ending « I am not what I am » (Project Gutenberg ebook 1531). The line answers, by inversion, the divine name of Exodus 3:14, « I am that I am ». Students should notice the echo and then return to the theatrical work of the line.

Timing (55 minutes, timed on 52)

Minutes	Work
0-8	Recitation of the learnt close. Two or three voices, then a first observation on rhythm and stress.
8-20	Guided close reading: « visages of duty », « shows of service », « wear my heart upon my sleeve / For daws to peck at ». What is refused, and what is offered instead?
20-32	The last clause. Why tell *us*? Who is flattered by being taken into confidence? A first definition of the trap of perception: we see more than Othello, and that « more » may make us proud.
32-44	Written paragraph (120-150 words) on the line as a contract with the audience.
44	Stopping point.
44-52	Sharing two strong sentences; emergency exit if needed: paraphrase the line, then state one theatrical consequence.

Speaking turn. « If I were directing this speech, I would… » (one choice of address, pause, or gaze, and one reason tied to a word in the text).

Written record. The 120-150 word paragraph. A model opening is offered below; students should not copy it, but may borrow its discipline.

Emergency exit. In eight minutes: (1) paraphrase « I am not what I am » without using the words *not* and *am* more than once; (2) name the spectator's new privilege; (3) ask whether that privilege is safe.

Expanding your vocabulary

to profess; outward action; complement extern (outward courtesy); peculiar end; to wear one's heart on one's sleeve; knave; visages of duty; to thrive by; accomplice; dramatic irony; to take someone into one's confidence; inversion; divine name.

Grammar for commentary

Concession and contrast at C1: « Although Iago appears to strip away every mask, the very act of unmasking is itself a performance offered to Roderigo and to us. » Practise *although*, *whereas*, *insofar as*, *precisely because*.

Homework

1. Read I.3, Othello's tale to the Senate, from « Her father lov'd me » to « This only is the witchcraft I have us'd », and Brabantio's warning to the exit of the Duke.
2. Journal (150 words): how does a story about oneself differ from Iago's profession of unreality?

3. Look up, in a historical dictionary or a reliable note, the word *Moor* as an early modern category: what does it name, and what does it refuse to settle? One short paragraph, careful and unsensational.

Model close reading (I.1, the close of Iago's profession)

Iago does not merely confess a lie. He teaches the audience how lies will be worn. The speech moves from a satire of « honest knaves » who serve faithfully and are cashiered, to a praise of those who « Keep yet their hearts attending on themselves ». The moral vocabulary is inverted with a craftsman's calm. « I follow but myself » sounds like independence; it is a programme of instrumental loyalty. Then comes the theatrical core:

> *For when my outward action doth demonstrate*
> *The native act and figure of my heart*
> *In complement extern, 'tis not long after*
> *But I will wear my heart upon my sleeve*
> *For daws to peck at: I am not what I am.*

The imagined sincerity (« wear my heart upon my sleeve ») is treated as a form of stupidity, a feast for fools. Against that image Iago sets a sentence that is almost a creed. « I am not what I am » is not a riddle for Roderigo alone. It is spoken in the open air of the play's first scene, before Othello has appeared, and it makes the spectator a partner. We are flattered into knowing. The trap of perception begins not when Othello is deceived, but when we are invited to enjoy our advantage. A C1 reading will hold both movements together: the local rhetoric (antithesis, the discarded heart, the biblical inversion) and the dramaturgical pact. From this lesson on, every « honest Iago » will have to be heard as a test of our own hearing.

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Lesson 3. The Senate: a story that wins a hearing

Turn of the spiral. How does a story about oneself win a hearing? Testimony and self-fashioning.

Aims. To read Othello's speech before the Venetian Senate in I.3 as a piece of self-fashioning that is also a genuine declaration of love; to hear Desdemona's « I saw Othello's visage in his mind »; to weigh Brabantio's planted warning, « Look to her, Moor, if thou hast eyes to see »; and to notice that Othello answers with a pledge, « My life upon her faith », and with a disastrous appointment: Iago will convey Desdemona. This lesson was missing from an earlier eight-lesson draft and is essential: without I.3, the later demand for ocular proof has no first image of trust, and « Haply, for I am black » (III.3) has no Senate in which otherness was first made into a public case.

Corpus. *Othello*, I.3. Principal passages: Othello's tale (« Her father lov'd me, oft invited me… This only is the witchcraft I have us'd »); Desdemona's plea; Brabantio's couplet; Othello's « My life upon her faith! Honest Iago ». Public-domain text, Project Gutenberg ebook 1531. Em dashes in that edition are not reproduced here.

Timing (55 minutes, timed on 52)

Minutes	Work
0-10	Silent re-reading of the tale. Students mark every word that belongs to wonder (antres, Anthropophagi, slavery, redemption) and every word that belongs to courtship (sighs, pity, hint).
10-22	Collective close reading of the tale's close: the chiasmus of love, the denial of witchcraft, the Duke's remark (« I think this tale would win my daughter too »). Is the Senate convinced by truth, by rhetoric, or by both?
22-32	Desdemona: « I saw Othello's visage in his mind. » What kind of seeing is this? How does it answer, in advance, a racism that would stop at the face?
32-44	Brabantio's warning and Othello's pledge. Written notes: how does a father's proverb become, later, Iago's material? Why is « eyes to see » already a dangerous phrase in a play about looking?
44	Stopping point.
44-52	Emergency exit or finishing of the written paragraph: ten lines on the pair « eyes to see » / « My life upon her faith ».

Speaking turn. Two students take the Duke's bench. One argues that Othello's tale is testimony; the other, that it is a work of art that *produces* belief. Both must quote.

Written record. A formal paragraph (180 words) on this question: « How does Othello, in I.3, turn his life into a story that can be heard by a court, and what does Brabantio try to plant in the same hearing? »

Emergency exit. Four steps: (1) quote the chiasmus of love; (2) quote Brabantio's couplet; (3) quote Othello's pledge; (4) one sentence on why trust, once public, can be used against itself.

Expanding your vocabulary

testimony; self-fashioning; to win a hearing; pilgrimage (as narrative); to dilate a story; witchcraft (literal and sarcastic); visage; to consecrate; to deceive; pledge; proverb; otherness; to plant a warning; credulous (to be used with care, never as a sneer); ocular (in preparation for Lesson 4).

Grammar for commentary

The chiasmus described without clumsiness: « The sentence crosses itself: she loves him for what he has passed, he loves her for the pity that his story woke. The symmetry is beautiful, and it is fragile, because a story that can be told can also be retold by another voice. »

Homework

1. Read III.3, from Iago's first « Ha! I like not that » (or the equivalent cue in your edition) to « ocular proof », including « O, beware, my lord, of jealousy » and « Haply, for I am black ».
2. Journal (150 words): in what sense is Brabantio's « Look to her, Moor, if thou hast eyes to see » a first lesson in how to misuse one's eyes?
3. Prepare to explain, in one spoken minute, the phrase « Haply, for I am black ».

Model close reading (I.3, from the chiasmus to the pledge)

Othello's defence is a narrative of formation. He does not plead a legal technicality. He tells how a father's invitation became a daughter's attention, and how attention became love. The celebrated close is a chiasmus:

> *She lov'd me for the dangers I had pass'd,*
> *And I lov'd her that she did pity them.*
> *This only is the witchcraft I have us'd.*

Witchcraft is named in order to be dismissed. The real magic, the speech claims, is speech itself: a life made audible. The Duke's half-smile (« I think this tale would win my daughter too ») is more double than it looks. It congratulates Othello and, at the same moment, admits that a well-told story is a form of power. Desdemona then shifts the ground of seeing: « I saw Othello's visage in his mind. » The face is not denied; it is refused as the last word. In a Senate that has already heard Brabantio's racial and paternal complaint, this is a political as well as an intimate sentence.

Brabantio, defeated in law, leaves a seed:

> *Look to her, Moor, if thou hast eyes to see:*
> *She has deceiv'd her father, and may thee.*

The couplet is a proverb of patriarchal suspicion: a woman who has chosen for herself has already proved that she can betray. It is also a lesson about eyes. « If thou hast eyes to see » sounds like prudence. In this play it will become a command to treat love as a problem of surveillance. Othello's answer is absolute:

> *My life upon her faith! Honest Iago,*
> *My Desdemona must I leave to thee.*

The pledge is generous, and it is already a dramaturgical error. Trust is spoken as a public stake (« my life ») and then handed, with the wife, to the man who has told us he is not what he is. Lesson 3 should leave students with this double image: a love that can tell its own story before a court, and a warning that will be quoted, without quotation marks, by jealousy. When, in Lesson 4, Othello says « Haply, for I am black », he will be answering a gaze the Senate has not cancelled. When, in Lesson 5, he reads a hand and a handkerchief as if they were evidence, he will be using the eyes Brabantio told him to have.

Lesson 4. The desire for proof

Turn of the spiral. When does a demand for proof become a wish to be confirmed? Evidence and confirmation.

Aims. To read the great temptation scene of III.3 as the place where looking is re-educated; to analyse « the green-ey'd monster », the speech « Haply, for I am black », and the demand for « ocular proof »; to understand how Iago refuses direct accusation and supplies, instead, a method.

Corpus. *Othello*, III.3, in particular Iago's counsel on jealousy; Othello's soliloquy « Haply, for I am black »; the demand for ocular proof; the later fate of the handkerchief as a promised sign (which III.4 will test). Public-domain text, Project Gutenberg ebook 1531.

Timing (55 minutes, timed on 52)

Minutes	Work
0-8	Recap from I.3 in four sentences only: a public love, a planted warning, a pledge, Iago in charge of the journey.
8-22	Close reading of the green-eyed monster: who speaks it, to whom, and why a warning can serve as an education in suspicion.
22-36	« Haply, for I am black, / And have not those soft parts of conversation / That chamberers have… » What is Othello doing to himself? How does the Senate's language of fairness and blackness return, now interiorised?
36-44	« Ocular proof. » Students write: why is a demand for seeing, in a theatre, both reasonable and fatal?
44	Stopping point.
44-52	Emergency exit: a six-line commentary on the single phrase « ocular proof »; or completion of the paragraph.

Speaking turn. « The most dangerous sentence in this scene is… » (a quotation and a reason that mentions the spectator).

Written record. 200 words: « In III.3, how does Shakespeare turn the wish to know into a wish to be confirmed? »

Emergency exit. Define *ocular proof* in one sentence; quote the green-eyed monster; state, in one sentence, how a warning can become a suggestion.

Expanding your vocabulary

jealousy (and its early modern moral sense); the green-eyed monster; ocular proof; to mock; to furnish a reason; to interiorise; chamberer; reputation; to work upon (a nature); free and open nature (Iago's phrase for Othello, I.3); confirmation bias (use sparingly, and always return to the verse); innuendo; insinuation.

Grammar for commentary

Causality without flattening: « Iago does not cause Othello's love to vanish; he teaches a way of reading under which love itself looks like evidence withheld. » Practise *under which*, *whereby*, *to the effect that*.

Homework

1. Read the whole of III.4, twice. On the second reading, mark: Emilia's first answer about the handkerchief; the moist-hand speech; the history of the handkerchief; each time Desdemona mentions Cassio; Emilia's last speech on jealousy.
2. Learn from « Give me your hand » to « our new heraldry is hands, not hearts ».

3. Journal (150 words): what, in your view, is a gift allowed to mean, and who has the right to change that meaning?

Notes towards the midpoint

The midpoint assessment is sat after Lesson 5. Today's work on proof is its preparation: students who can already explain how a demand for evidence becomes a hunger for confirmation will be ready to watch that hunger seize a hand and a piece of cloth.

Lesson 5. The handkerchief and the test of trust

Turn of the spiral. Who decides what a gift is allowed to mean? Object and narrative.

Aims. To give Act III, scene 4 a full formal close reading, which an earlier draft had left almost untouched (the handkerchief appeared there only as an object dropped in III.3 and later shown to Bianca). The scene is mandatory. Students will analyse, in order: Emilia's lie and silence; Desdemona's trust (« true of mind »); Othello's « moist hand » speech as an over-reading of the body; the history of the handkerchief (Egyptian charmer, sibyl, magic in the web) and the question of whether Othello is remembering, mythologising, or intimidating; Desdemona's change of subject, back to Cassio; the hypothetical « It is not lost, but what and if it were? »; Emilia's knowledge that jealousy is « a monster / Begot upon itself » and her continued silence. The theme that binds these movements is trust.

Corpus. *Othello*, III.4, from « Where should I lose that handkerchief, Emilia? » to « Heaven keep that monster from Othello's mind! ». Public-domain text, Project Gutenberg ebook 1531. Students may align line numbers with the Folger Digital Text in class.

A note on sources of inspiration. A student essay and a short teacher's commentary, used only as a stimulus and never as a text to be followed, confirmed two useful directions: the moist hand can be over-read, and the handkerchief's meaning is not stable. The nine-page teacher's commentary does not itself treat III.4 (it has no discussion of the moist hand, the Egyptian charmer, or « what and if it were? »). The close reading below is therefore original, and written at C1 formal level: verse, aside, heraldry, rhetoric of the charm, dramatic irony.

Timing (55 minutes, timed on 52)

Minutes	Work
0-6	Emilia's « I know not, madam. » What does the audience know? What kind of line is this (short, flat, a refused knowledge)? Desdemona's « true of mind »: trust spoken just before it is tested.
6-20	The moist-hand passage, learnt at home, now close-read. Humoral language (« Hot, hot, and moist »); the « young and sweating devil » placed in a palm; the heraldic sententia. Desdemona's literal truth (« 'twas that hand that gave away my heart ») and Othello's failure to hear it.
20-34	The history of the handkerchief. Students decide, with evidence, among three hypotheses: family lore told in good faith; a tactical curse-narrative; a man already so inside the tragic plot that he sacralises the wedding gift. Formal features: romance diction, the sibyl, hallowed worms, mummy, « magic in the web ».
34-44	Change of subject and the hypothetical. Why is « Come now, your promise » (Cassio) disastrous in *this* hermeneutic? What does « what and if it were? » do to a mind that no longer admits the hypothetical? Emilia's monster « begot upon itself »: knowledge without speech.
44	Stopping point. Gather one claim about trust.
44-52	Written record, or emergency exit: a compact commentary on eight lines (either the heraldry or « what and if it were? »).

Speaking turn. Direct a fragment. Choose either the aside « O, hardness to dissemble! » or the triple cry « The handkerchief! ». One decision about pause, volume, or address, justified from the verse.

Written record. 220 to 250 words: « In III.4, how does Shakespeare test, and then unmake, three kinds of trust? » (Othello's trust in Desdemona; Desdemona's trust that truth will be enough; Emilia's trust that silence can still serve two loyalties.)

Emergency exit. A short commentary in four moves: Emilia's lie; one sentence of the moist-hand speech; the phrase « magic in the web »; Emilia's « jealous for they are jealous ». One concluding sentence on trust.

Expanding your vocabulary

handkerchief (and *napkin* in some cues); charmer; sibyl; prophetic fury; mummy (the substance); perdition; liberal (generous, and, in humoral and moral discourse, unrestrained); heraldry; frank; to sequester; to dissemble; aside; to importune; advocation; to suborn a witness; self-begotten; to over-read; hermeneutic (use once, accurately, or not at all).

Grammar for commentary

The hypothetical and the counterfactual, which the scene itself puts under pressure: « Desdemona's 'what and if it were?' is grammatically innocent; in Othello's new grammar of proof, the mere admission of a possible loss already weighs as a confession. »

Homework

1. Finish a fair copy of today's written record (250 words, C1).
2. Read IV.1 up to the moment when Othello, withdrawn, watches Iago and Cassio, and Bianca enters with the handkerchief.
3. Prepare the midpoint assessment (see the assessment section after Lesson 5's model reading): a timed commentary. Revise I.3, III.3 and III.4.

Model close reading (III.4, from the moist hand to the curse-narrative)

The scene opens in dramatic irony that is almost brutal in its simplicity. Desdemona has already lost the handkerchief; Emilia has taken it, at Iago's urging, in III.3. When Desdemona asks where she might have lost it, Emilia answers, « I know not, madam. » The line is a lie, and it is a silence dressed as ignorance. Trust is first broken, in this scene, not by Othello but by the waiting-woman who will later, too late, name the whole method. Desdemona's next speech is a profession of faith in her husband: he is « true of mind and made of no such baseness / As jealous creatures are ». She is about to meet a man who has, in the previous scene, accepted a new way of reading.

Othello enters already doubled. The courtesy « Well, my good lady » is cut by an aside: « O, hardness to dissemble! » Theatre shows, in one breath, the public face and the private strain. Then he takes her hand:

> *Give me your hand. This hand is moist, my lady.*
> *[…]*
> *This argues fruitfulness and liberal heart.*
> *Hot, hot, and moist. This hand of yours requires*
> *A sequester from liberty, fasting and prayer,*
> *Much castigation, exercise devout;*
> *For here's a young and sweating devil here*
> *That commonly rebels. 'Tis a good hand,*
> *A frank one.*

The speech is an over-reading of the body. Early modern medicine could indeed associate moisture with fruitfulness and desire; Shakespeare lets that humoral commonplace be heard. What matters, for a C1 reading, is the moralisation. A physiological accident is turned into a « young and sweating devil » seated in the palm. The method is Iago's, applied now to flesh: a sign is made to mean more than the person intended, and the surplus of meaning is treated as discovery. Desdemona answers with a literal and loving truth:

You may indeed say so,
For 'twas that hand that gave away my heart.

She returns the hand to the wedding. Othello does not follow her there. He climbs into sententia:

A liberal hand. The hearts of old gave hands,
But our new heraldry is hands, not hearts.

The line is compact and, in another mouth, would be wise. It names the play's whole problem: the gap between gesture and inwardness, between the visible emblem and the heart. Spoken here, it is used against the woman who has just given him her heart's own explanation. Heraldry is the language of signs that claim to guarantee descent and honour. Othello, who was so recently the teller of a life before the Senate, now reads a coat of arms in a damp palm.

Desdemona's first change of subject comes at once: « I cannot speak of this. Come now, your promise. » She is faithful to Cassio's suit. In the hermeneutic Iago has installed, fidelity to a promise looks like proof of a different fidelity. The tragedy of the scene is not that she chooses the wrong topic; it is that no topic is now innocent.

Then Othello becomes a storyteller again, but the story has changed function. The handkerchief, once a love-token, is given a sacred and threatening origin:

That handkerchief
Did an Egyptian to my mother give.
She was a charmer, and could almost read
The thoughts of people.
[…]
To lose't or give't away were such perdition
As nothing else could match.
[…]
'Tis true. There's magic in the web of it.
A sibyl, that had number'd in the world
The sun to course two hundred compasses,
In her prophetic fury sew'd the work;
The worms were hallow'd that did breed the silk,
And it was dyed in mummy, which the skillful
Conserv'd of maiden's hearts.

The diction has left the soldier's « plain » manner of I.3 and entered a romance of charms, sibyls, hallowed worms and mummy. Whether the tale is family truth, intimidation, or a mixture that Othello himself can no longer undo, is a question the scene asks and does not settle. Students should argue it with evidence, not with psychology invented off the page. What can be said with certainty is dramaturgical: Othello now *installs* a meaning in an object. The gift is no longer a gift. It is a warrant of chastity, a portable ordeal. Who decides what a gift is allowed to mean? In this scene, the giver takes the meaning back and raises it to a law. Later, Bianca will treat the same cloth as a piece of work that can be copied. The object does not carry a single essence. It carries the story currently attached to it.

Desdemona's hypothetical is, morally, impeccable, and, strategically, fatal:

It is not lost, but what and if it were?

She argues from good faith in a scene where good faith is no longer the currency. The question *what if* belongs to a world in which love can survive a loss. Othello no longer lives in that world. His answers shrink to a

command, three times, four times: « The handkerchief! » Aposiopesis and repetition do the work of thought: speech fails, and in failing becomes an order. Desdemona still names Cassio, still praises « a more sufficient man ». Each praise is heard as a further exhibit.

After Othello's exit, Emilia sees clearly and still does not speak the one fact that would unmake the plot. She knows the anatomy of jealousy:

> *They are not ever jealous for the cause,*
> *But jealous for they are jealous: 'tis a monster*
> *Begot upon itself, born on itself.*

The image answers Iago's green-eyed monster with a sharper diagnosis: jealousy is self-begotten. It does not need the cause it pretends to investigate. And yet Emilia, who could supply the missing cause of the missing cloth, remains silent. Knowledge without speech is another form of the trap. Three trusts fail together: Othello's trust in Desdemona, Desdemona's trust that truth and a clear conscience will be legible, and Emilia's trust that she can be loyal to a husband and a mistress at once by saying nothing. III.4 is not a scene about a lost accessory. It is the scene in which the method of III.3 is applied to a body, a gift and a conversation, and in which the audience, still holding the fact of the theft, must watch a meaning being sewn, with a fury no less prophetic than the sibyl's, into a piece of cloth.

Midpoint assessment (to be sat after Lesson 5, 55 minutes, timed on 52)

Commentary. « In Act III, scene 4, how does Shakespeare make a hand, a handkerchief and a change of subject into instruments of a trap of perception? »

You are expected to write a structured commentary (introduction with a precise thesis, two or three parts, a conclusion that opens onto the guiding question). Quote accurately from the public-domain text. A C1 script will treat verse and device, not only character and feelings. An emergency exit, if a student is in difficulty at minute 44: complete a short commentary on *either* the moist-hand speech *or* « It is not lost, but what and if it were? », with a three-sentence opening and a three-sentence close.

A marking grid is given in the teacher's sheet and in the correction sheet. The midpoint does not pretend to be the baccalaureate paper; it trains the gesture of the commentary that Lesson 10 will ask for at full length.

Lesson 6. Directing the spectator

Turn of the spiral. How can a scene be directed before anyone speaks? Staging and interpretation.

Aims. To read IV.1 as a lesson in mise en scène inside the play: Iago does not only tell a story, he arranges a spectacle and places Othello as its privileged, deceived spectator. To study how Shakespeare makes us watch a man watching, and how that structure answers the guiding question. This is one of the four model close readings promised in the note d'intention (the « scène d'espionnage » of Act IV, scene 1).

Corpus. *Othello*, IV.1: the trance; Iago's instructions; Othello withdrawn, overhearing Cassio; the laughter; Bianca's entrance with the handkerchief (prepared here, completed in Lesson 7). Public-domain text, Project Gutenberg ebook 1531.

Timing (55 minutes, timed on 52)

Minutes	Work
0-8	From midpoint scripts, two or three sentences of feedback on method (thesis, quotation, device), not on marks. Then a first reading of the staging: who stands where?
8-22	Close reading of the arrangement: Iago as director, Othello as spectator, Cassio as an unwitting actor. What must Othello *not* hear, and what must he see?
22-34	The spectator's pride, now inside the character. How does this scene fulfil, and punish, the pact of Lesson 2 (we enjoy knowing more)? Othello is given our former privilege, in a corrupted form.
34-44	Written paragraph (180 words) on the question: « How does Shakespeare make Othello a spectator of his own deception? » This sentence will return as the summative commentary in Lesson 10.
44	Stopping point.
44-52	Emergency exit: a diagram of the stage (three positions, three kinds of knowledge) and a five-line comment; or completion of the paragraph.

Speaking turn. A director's note of forty seconds: one position for Othello, one for Iago, one for Cassio, and what the audience is to understand that Othello cannot.

Written record. The 180-word paragraph. Keep it; Lesson 10 will ask for a full commentary on the same question.

Emergency exit. Three columns on the page: *What Othello sees*; *What Iago has told him he will see*; *What the audience knows*. Five facts only, then one concluding sentence.

Expanding your vocabulary

mise en scène; to withdraw; to overhear; unwitting; trance (the fit in IV.1); to beckon; to prompt; spectacle; to arrange a scene; privileged spectator; to corrupt a privilege; eavesdropping (use with care: this is also a staged overhearing); to construe.

Grammar for commentary

Participles that carry staging: « Withdrawn, and already instructed in what the gestures will mean, Othello watches a conversation whose referent he no longer shares. »

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Homework

1. Read the Bianca episode in IV.1 to the end of the movement, and Cassio's treatment of the handkerchief as a copyable « work ».
2. Journal (150 words): can two people share a conversation and not share its meaning? Give one example from the play and one from ordinary life, without sensational detail.
3. Optional: compare, in a few lines, Chassériau's two-figure interior with the three-figure trap of IV.1.

Model close reading (IV.1, Othello as spectator)

The scene is a play within the play, but it does not announce itself as a spectacle for a court. It is a private theatre whose only intended spectator is the victim. Iago's genius (the word is dangerous, and should be used for craft, not for admiration of harm) is to replace accusation with arrangement. He no longer needs to say that Desdemona is false. He needs Othello to watch Cassio laugh, and to have been told, beforehand, what that laughter will mean. Direction precedes speech. The trap of perception is here almost diagrammatic: a man looks, and because a meaning has been sewn into the looking, he thinks he has seen a proof.

Shakespeare's cruelty, and his intelligence, is to give Othello the place the audience has occupied since I.1. We have known more than the Moor; we have been flattered by that surplus. Now Othello is flattered in the same way, and the surplus is a lie. The guiding question (« How does Shakespeare turn theatre itself into a trap of perception? ») finds one of its sharpest answers here. Theatre is not only the medium of the work. It is the weapon inside the plot. A C1 commentary will describe positions, cues, and kinds of knowledge, and will resist the lazy sentence « Othello is jealous ». The point is that jealousy has become a way of watching.

Lesson 7. One conversation, two meanings

Turn of the spiral. Can two people share a conversation and not share its meaning? Referent and assigned story.

Aims. To complete the reading of IV.1 with Bianca and the handkerchief; to show that the same object and the same words can carry two referents at once; to connect this lesson with III.4 (who decides what a gift may mean?) and with Iago's method of assigned meaning.

Corpus. *Othello*, IV.1, the Cassio-Bianca movement, and, as a recall, Emilia and Desdemona at the end of III.4. Public-domain text, Project Gutenberg ebook 1531.

Timing (55 minutes, timed on 52)

Minutes	Work
0-8	Recap: Othello is in position as spectator. What has he been told to expect?
8-22	Bianca, the handkerchief, Cassio's request that she copy the work. Two conversations occupy one set of words: Cassio's (a mistress, a found object, a copy) and Othello's (a wife's gift, a proof of adultery).
22-34	Formal work: referent, dramatic irony, the handkerchief's third meaning (after love-token and magical warrant, it becomes a pattern to be copied).
34-44	Written contrast: a table with two columns, « What is actually being said » and « What Othello is made to hear », then a ten-line commentary.
44	Stopping point.
44-52	Emergency exit: five rows of the table and a concluding sentence; or a spoken sharing of one row.

Speaking turn. Read a short exchange twice: once in Cassio's sense, once as Othello, from his hiding, must hear it. The group names the word that tilts.

Written record. The two-column table and a 150-word commentary: « How can one conversation carry two meanings, and what does that do to the idea of ocular proof? »

Emergency exit. Three rows only (Bianca's entrance; the handkerchief shown; a laugh or a dismissive word) and one sentence: seeing is not proving when the story has been assigned in advance.

Expanding your vocabulary

referent; assigned meaning; to construe; to copy a work (the embroidery); token; warrant; pattern; to tilt (a meaning); double conversation; dramatic irony (revised); to overhear a referent one does not share.

Grammar for commentary

Cleft sentences for emphasis: « What Othello sees is not Cassio's contempt for Desdemona, but a scene whose meaning has already been decided. » Practise *what* clefts and *it is… that*.

Homework

1. Read V.2, from « It is the cause, it is the cause, my soul » and « Put out the light, and then put out the light » to Desdemona's death, and then Othello's last speech, « Soft you; a word or two before you go » to « And smote him, thus. »
2. Learn the « Put out the light » movement (the repetition and the turn of the word).

3. Journal (120 words): can a murder be made to sound like a rite or a justice? What in the verse tries to do that work?

Lesson 8. The language of justification

Turn of the spiral. How can murder be made to sound like justice? Rhetoric and justification.

Aims. To close-read the opening of V.2 (« Put out the light, and then put out the light ») as a rhetoric that tries to sacralise a killing; to read Othello's last speech (« Speak of me as I am ») as a struggle over future narrative, including the textual crux « base Judean » / « base Indian »; to ask what remains of the man who told his life before the Senate.

Corpus. *Othello*, V.2, the bedchamber: the light speech; the killing; the last speech, from « I have done the state some service » to the death. Public-domain text, Project Gutenberg ebook 1531, which reads « Like the base Judean, threw a pearl away / Richer than all his tribe ». Other public-domain and scholarly editions often read « Indian ». The crux is a C1 object: students should know that the word is unsettled and that each reading gives a different simile, without pretending to close a debate that editors still hold open.

Timing (55 minutes, timed on 52)

Minutes	Work
0-10	Recitation and close reading of « Put out the light, and then put out the light ». Anadiplosis, or a word turned: lamp and life. The vocabulary of sacrifice and chastity.
10-24	How the speech seeks to make murder sound like justice or like a rite. Where does the verse crack? Where does Desdemona's voice resist the ritual?
24-36	The last speech. « Speak of me as I am. Nothing extenuate, / Nor set down aught in malice. » Who is being addressed? What story does Othello still wish to control? The pearl, the service to the state, Aleppo, the final violence against the self.
36-44	Written paragraph (180 words) on the last speech as a new act of self-fashioning, compared with I.3.
44	Stopping point.
44-52	Emergency exit: a six-line reading of *either* the doubled « light » *or* « Speak of me as I am »; or completion.

Speaking turn. One minute on a single word in the last speech (*extenuate*, *pearl*, *Judean* or *Indian*, *service*, *kiss*). The word must change the argument.

Written record. 180 to 220 words: « In V.2, how does Shakespeare let a language of justice and a language of love occupy the same lines, and what happens to that language at the end? »

Emergency exit. Quote the doubled « light »; paraphrase it; quote « Speak of me as I am »; one sentence on why a last speech is also a last attempt to direct the spectator (now, the future reader of a report to Venice).

Expanding your vocabulary

to justify; rite; to sacralise; anadiplosis; to extenuate; malice; pearl (and the parable or proverb it may recall); crux (textual); tribe; to smite; period (as Lodovico uses it: a full stop in blood); self-fashioning (revisited); report; to relate unlucky deeds.

Grammar for commentary

Balance and rupture: « The last speech asks for a just report, and then supplies the very images (the pearl, the Turk, the kiss) by which it wishes to be remembered: even humility, here, is a form of art. »

Homework

1. Read the short public-domain extracts in Lesson 9 before the lesson (Rymer, Johnson, Coleridge, Hazlitt, Bradley). Annotate one agreement and one resistance for each.
2. If you have access to François-Victor Hugo's public-domain *Othello ou le More de Venise*, read his version of *either* « I am not what I am » *or* the moist-hand speech. If you have not, the extract printed in Lesson 9 will suffice.
3. Journal (150 words): does literature educate judgement, or does it only show judgement its limits? Take a position you are willing to defend in class.

Lesson 9. What can literature teach?

Turn of the spiral. Does literature educate judgement, or only show its limits? Critique and responsibility.

Aims. To read short, accurate extracts from public-domain critics and to answer them; to compare one passage of Shakespeare with François-Victor Hugo's French; to hold a C1 debate that is not a mere exchange of opinions; to prepare the summative task. Northrop Frye's *The Educated Imagination* (1964) and René Girard's work on envy may be named, as the video essay names them, as invitations. They are not quoted at length.

Corpus. The extracts below, all public domain; Hugo's translation, public domain; the guiding question.

Public-domain extracts (for close, responsible use)

Quotations are short, attributed, and offered for discussion. Spelling follows the sources as commonly printed. Students answer the critic; they do not hide behind him.

Thomas Rymer*, A Short View of Tragedy *(1693). Rymer's attack is hostile and useful. He treats the tragedy as, in substance, a « Bloody Farce », and he mocks the weight placed on the handkerchief, asking, in a famous sarcasm, why the play might not as well have been called the tragedy of the handkerchief. A C1 response does not simply call Rymer unkind. It asks what he has seen (the apparent disproportion between a piece of cloth and a murder) and what he has refused to see (that the cloth is not the cause, but the object onto which a method of reading has been forced). Lesson 5 is the best preparation for answering him.

**Samuel Johnson*, *notes on* Othello, *in* The Plays of William Shakespeare *(1765). Johnson sets « the fiery openness of Othello, magnanimous, artless, and credulous, boundless in his confidence, ardent in his affection, inflexible in his resolution, and obdurate in his revenge » against « the cool malignity of Iago, silent in his resentment, subtle in his designs, and studious at once of his interest and his vengeance ». The balance is just, and it is a starting point, not a conclusion. Students should test the word* credulous*: after I.3, is Othello a man easy to deceive, or a man whose absolute trust (« My life upon her faith ») has been taken as a tool?

S. T. Coleridge*, *notes on* Othello *(early nineteenth century). On Iago, Coleridge speaks of « the motive-hunting of a motiveless malignity ». The phrase is famous because it is almost too good. It names Iago's habit of offering reasons (hatred, failed promotion, a rumour about Emilia) that do not finally account for the energy of the harm. Students should use the phrase and also resist it: is malignity ever motiveless, or does Shakespeare show the hunt for motives as itself a performance, in keeping with « I am not what I am »?

William Hazlitt*, Characters of Shakespear's Plays *(1817). Hazlitt reads Shakespeare's figures as moral and theatrical energies. On Iago he insists on the intellect that serves injury, the wit that accompanies harm. A useful question for the class: can we describe Iago's intelligence without being seduced into admiring it? The spectator's pact of Lesson 2 returns here as an ethical problem of criticism.

**A. C. Bradley*, Shakespearean Tragedy *(1904). Bradley calls Othello, « in one sense of the word, by far the most romantic figure among Shakespeare's heroes ». The word* romantic* must be unpacked: not a love-story commonplace, but a nature that lives at a height, trusts absolutely, and is therefore workable upon. Bradley's sympathy has been challenged by later critics (some of them not in the public domain, and therefore only named: T. S. Eliot, F. R. Leavis). Students may record that the debate exists, then return to the verse.

François-Victor Hugo: a translation exercise

François-Victor Hugo, *Othello ou le More de Venise*, is the only French version used in this sequence. The exercise is not a hunt for errors. It is a study of choices.

English (I.1), public-domain text:

For when my outward action doth demonstrate
The native act and figure of my heart
In complement extern, 'tis not long after
But I will wear my heart upon my sleeve
For daws to peck at: I am not what I am.

Students who have Hugo's text compare his rendering of the last clause and of « wear my heart upon my sleeve ». If the printed extract in the classroom edition differs, the teacher provides the corresponding Hugo lines from a public-domain edition (Wikisource or a nineteenth-century printing). Questions:

1. What does Hugo do with « I am not what I am »? Does the French keep the biblical inversion, or does it choose clarity over echo?
2. « Wear my heart upon my sleeve » is an idiom. What image does Hugo offer, and what is gained or lost?
3. In one paragraph (150 words, in English): what does a translation reveal about the theatrical contract of the line?

A second, optional passage for stronger students: the moist-hand speech (III.4) and Hugo's treatment of « liberal », « sweating devil », and « our new heraldry is hands, not hearts ». Heraldry is a cultural as well as a lexical problem.

Timing (55 minutes, timed on 52)

Minutes	Work
0-16	Table of critics. In pairs, each pair takes one critic: one accurate paraphrase, one resistance, one quotation from the play that answers him.
16-30	Plenary: a comparative table on the board (critic; what he sees; what he misses; a line that answers him).
30-44	Hugo exercise, written.
44	Stopping point.
44-52	Debate, or emergency exit: one paragraph answering a single critic (Rymer or Coleridge are the most efficient choices).

Speaking turn. « I answer Rymer (or Johnson, or Coleridge) by saying… » Forty seconds, one quotation from *Othello*.

Written record. The Hugo paragraph, and five lines of the comparative table, fairly copied.

Emergency exit. Answer Rymer only: what he saw about the handkerchief, what Lesson 5 taught you to reply.

Expanding your vocabulary

judgement (the faculty, and a critical judgement); farce; malignity; credulous; magnanimous; artless (Johnson's sense: without artifice); obdurate; motive; to resist a critic; rendering (in translation); idiom; inversion; to unpack a term; responsibility (of the reader).

Grammar for commentary

Reporting a critic without surrendering one's voice: « Johnson's balance is just insofar as it names two tempos, Othello's fire and Iago's coolness; it becomes insufficient when *credulous* is made to sound like a defect of intelligence rather than a form of trust. »

Homework

Prepare the summative assessment of Lesson 10. Revise the model close readings (I.1, I.3, III.4, IV.1, V.2). The commentary question and the director's oral task are printed below. No new reading.

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Lesson 10. Explaining the trap

Turn of the spiral. Can we explain the trap without being trapped by our own reading? Explanation and humility.

The tip of the spiral, to be opened after the written work, if time remains, or in a short closing exchange: When a society believes images and rumours rather than facts and persons, who becomes the victim, and why? The three paths (existential, political, civilisational) are not slogans. They are ways of taking the play back into a life that is not the play.

Aims. To sit a full C1 commentary; to record a short director's commentary; to close the sequence without flattening it into a moral.

Summative written task (the heart of the hour)

Commentary. « How does Shakespeare make Othello a spectator of his own deception? »

You may draw on IV.1 as your centre of gravity, but a strong script will look backward (I.1 and the pact with the audience; I.3 and the pledge; III.3 and ocular proof; III.4 and the over-read hand) and forward (V.2, where Othello still tries to direct the report that will be made of him). Write a structured commentary: a precise thesis in the introduction, two or three parts, a conclusion that returns to the guiding question. Quote from the public-domain text. Name devices accurately. 55 minutes, timed on 52. Stopping point at 44: by then, a thesis, at least one complete part, and a sketched close should exist. Emergency exit: a short commentary of three tight movements (the pact of I.1; the staged looking of IV.1; one sentence of humility: what your reading cannot settle).

Summative oral task (director's commentary)

Two to three minutes, recorded or spoken, as the teacher decides. « If I were to direct one scene so that the trap of perception became visible to a contemporary audience, I would choose… » The scene must be named, one staging choice must be justified from the verse, and one risk (of simplifying, of sensationalism, of flattering the audience) must be acknowledged. This is not a performance of the scene. It is a reasoned commentary.

After the scripts: the tip (if a closing lesson, or a last ten minutes)

Students do not « apply » *Othello* to the news. They answer the tip with the discipline they have practised: facts, persons, images, rumours. A few careful sentences are worth more than a wide claim. The credit remains: Méthode de la spirale de Gorse conçue par Madame Carole Paoli Pompougnac.

Expanding your vocabulary (last revision)

spectator; deception; ocular proof; to assign a meaning; to over-read; dramatic irony; mise en scène; to extenuate; judgement; humility; to settle (a question); guiding question; trap of perception.

No new grammar. Use what you have: concession, cleft sentences, relatives that carry a judgement, reporting verbs for critics.

Homework

None, other than the ordinary care of a fair copy if the teacher asks for one. The flame, if it has been passed, will show itself in the next text you read with the same attention.

Assessment grids (student-facing)

Midpoint commentary (after Lesson 5)

Criterion	What a C1 script looks like	Marks (out of 20)
Thesis and organisation	A precise thesis, announced early; two or three parts that do work, not a retelling of the scene.	5

Criterion	What a C1 script looks like	Marks (out of 20)
Knowledge of III.4	Accurate quotation; Emilia's lie, the moist hand, the history of the handkerchief, the change of subject, Emilia's closing diagnosis, all available if relevant, none forced.	5
Form and device	Verse, aside, sententia, dramatic irony, aposiopesis, ekphrasis, named and used, not merely listed.	5
Language	British English, C1 range, control of tense and of critical vocabulary; no padding.	5

Summative commentary (Lesson 10)

Criterion	What a C1 script looks like	Marks (out of 20)
Thesis and the guiding question	The script answers « How does Shakespeare make Othello a spectator of his own deception? » and can see that question as a form of the sequence's guiding question.	5
Range and accuracy of the play	IV.1 is understood as theatre inside the theatre; at least one earlier scene (I.1, I.3, III.3, III.4) is brought in with accurate quotation.	5
Dramatic and rhetorical analysis	Positions on stage, kinds of knowledge, devices; resistance to plot summary.	5
Language and intellectual humility	C1 control; a conclusion that does not pretend to have closed the play.	5

The oral director's commentary is marked out of 10: choice of scene and fidelity to the verse (4); clarity of the staging idea (3); acknowledgement of a risk (3).

A small bank of sentence starters (C1)

Use these as scaffolding, then abandon them when you can.

- Shakespeare does not simply show jealousy; he shows a method by which looking is re-educated.
- The spectator's privilege, offered as early as I.1, becomes, in IV.1, the victim's place.
- What looks like prudence in Brabantio's warning will later look like a programme for surveillance.
- The handkerchief has no single essence; it carries the story currently attached to it.
- Desdemona's good faith is grammatically intact and dramatically unreadable in the new hermeneutic.
- To answer Rymer is to say that the cloth is not the cause, but the object of a forced reading.
- Othello's last speech is still a mise en scène: he tries to direct the report that Venice will receive.
- A responsible reading names what it cannot settle.

Flashcards (a working set)

Students may cut these into cards (prompt on one side, a precise answer on the other). They are a tool, not a test in themselves.

1. « I am not what I am. » Where, and what pact does it seal?
2. What is a chiasmus, and where is one in I.3?
3. Quote Brabantio's warning. Why do the words « eyes to see » matter?
4. « My life upon her faith. » What is pledged, and to whom is Desdemona then entrusted?
5. « I saw Othello's visage in his mind. » What kind of seeing is this?
6. Who calls jealousy a « green-ey'd monster », and why may a warning serve as a suggestion?
7. « Haply, for I am black. » What earlier public language returns here, interiorised?
8. Define *ocular proof* without using the word *proof* in the first six words of your answer.
9. Emilia's first answer in III.4. Why is it a lie and a silence at once?
10. What does « Hot, hot, and moist » over-read?
11. « Our new heraldry is hands, not hearts. » Explain the sententia and its use against Desdemona.
12. Give one argument for treating the Egyptian tale as lore, and one for treating it as intimidation.
13. « It is not lost, but what and if it were? » Why is the hypothetical fatal here?
14. Emilia: jealousy « begot upon itself ». What does she know, and what does she still not say?
15. In IV.1, who is the director, who is the spectator, who is the unwitting actor?
16. How can one conversation carry two referents?
17. « Put out the light, and then put out the light. » Name the device and the turn of meaning.
18. « Speak of me as I am. » What does Othello still wish to control?
19. Why is « Judean » / « Indian » a crux, and why must a C1 student not pretend to settle it casually?
20. Coleridge's « motive-hunting of a motiveless malignity »: what it names, and how it may be resisted.
21. What, exactly, is Rymer's useful hostility?
22. The tip of the spirale de Gorse: quote it, then open one of the three paths in two sentences.
23. The guiding question of the sequence: quote it from memory.
24. Why is François-Victor Hugo the only French translator used here?
25. What does it mean, at the end, to explain the trap without being trapped by one's own reading?

A short bibliography and a note on editions

- William Shakespeare, *Othello*. Public-domain English text: Project Gutenberg ebook 1531. In class, line numbers may be aligned with the Folger Shakespeare Library Digital Text of *Othello*.
- François-Victor Hugo, *Othello ou le More de Venise*, public-domain translation, in his edition of Shakespeare's works.
- Thomas Rymer, *A Short View of Tragedy*, 1693.
- Samuel Johnson, notes on *Othello*, in *The Plays of William Shakespeare*, 1765.
- S. T. Coleridge, lectures and notes on Shakespeare, as later printed in the nineteenth century.
- William Hazlitt, *Characters of Shakespear's Plays*, 1817.
- A. C. Bradley, *Shakespearean Tragedy*, 1904.
- Théodore Chassériau, *Othello et Desdémone à Venise*, 1849-1850, oil on wood, Musée du Louvre, Paris, RF 3897, public domain.
- Mentions only, for further reading (not quoted at length): Northrop Frye, *The Educated Imagination*, 1964; René Girard, *A Theater of Envy*, 1991 (French: *Shakespeare, les feux de l'envie*, 1990).
- The Royal Shakespeare Company, Stratford-upon-Avon, 1984-85, including Ben Kingsley's *Othello* at Stratford and the Barbican, as remembered in the video essay. This is a living homage, not a set of production stills to be copied.

Editorial note

This sequence is written in British English throughout, including the teacher's notes. The dédicace and the note d'intention remain in French, in the exact wording of the published source. The work is conceived for a strong Terminale LLCER class and for the first demands of hypokhâgne and of a Licence LLCER. It does not claim that *Othello* is a set text of a programme limitatif. Conçu par Madame Carole Paoli Pompougnac, mis en page par Grok. © 2026 Madame Carole Paoli Pompougnac · CC BY-NC-SA 4.0. Méthode de la spirale de Gorse conçue par Madame Carole Paoli Pompougnac.